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FREE GUIDE

Buying Your First Home in Quebec

The 10 steps, explained simply

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> Buying your first home is exciting, but there are many steps and new terms. This guide gives you the big picture, in order, so you can move forward without surprises.

STEP 01

Take stock of your budget

- Add up your gross income, monthly debts (car, credit cards, loans) and available savings.
- Lenders mainly look at two ratios: the share of your income that goes to housing, and the share that goes to all your debts. Common benchmarks are about 39% and 44%.
- Also decide what monthly payment you're comfortable with, not just the maximum allowed.

STEP 02

Get pre-qualified

- A mortgage broker or your bank determines how much you can borrow.
- In Canada, you qualify at the higher of two rates: your rate + 2%, or 5.25% (the stress test).
- A pre-approval also holds a rate for a set period. It's an advantage when you make an offer.

STEP 03

Prepare your down payment

- Minimum: 5% up to $500,000; 10% on the portion between $500,000 and $1,499,999; 20% from $1.5M.
- Below 20%, mortgage default insurance (CMHC or another insurer) is required and added to the loan. In Quebec, the tax on the premium is paid in cash at the notary.
- To build your down payment, the FHSA and the HBP can be combined: up to $100,000 per person. All the details are in the "First-time buyer programs" section at the end of this guide.

STEP 04

Plan for closing costs

- Land transfer duties (the "welcome tax"): based on the price, with brackets that vary by municipality. Your city's calculator gives the exact amount. Good news: since 2026, Quebec refunds a large part of it to first-time buyers (up to $5,875, see the programs).
- Notary, pre-purchase inspection, municipal and school tax adjustments, home insurance, moving.
- Keep a reserve for these costs on top of your down payment. Your mortgage broker can help you estimate it.

STEP 05

Choose your real estate broker

- The seller's broker represents the seller. With your own broker, someone defends your interests as a buyer.
- Your broker helps you find the right homes, analyze the asking price and negotiate.
- Your commitments are set out in a brokerage contract to purchase: read it and ask questions.

STEP 06

Set your criteria and get alerts

- Separate your must-haves (bedrooms, area, parking) from your nice-to-haves.
- Receive matching new listings as soon as they hit the market.
- In popular areas, good homes sell fast: being ready makes the difference.

STEP 07

Make your visits count

- Bring your list of criteria and take photos and notes.
- Check the roof, windows, basement and heating system.
- Ask for the seller's declarations, tax bills and, for a condo, the condo fees and contingency fund.

STEP 08

Make an offer to purchase

- Your broker analyzes recent comparable sales to set a fair price.
- Conditions protect you: financing, inspection, and sometimes the sale of your current home.
- Each condition has a deadline. Respect them and keep everything in writing.

STEP

09

Inspection and final financing

- A building inspector examines the property. If a major issue comes up, your broker advises you on next steps.
- Your lender confirms the financing, often with an appraisal of the property.
- Once the conditions are met, the offer becomes firm.

STEP

10

At the notary and taking possession

- The notary checks the titles, prepares the deed of sale and the hypothec, and handles the adjustments.
- You sign, the notary pays the seller, and you get the keys on the agreed date.
- Remember to change your address, transfer your services and keep all your documents.

First-time buyer programs

Several programs can be combined. The amounts below are those in effect when this guide was written (October 2026): confirm your eligibility before counting on them.

Program	What you get	Main conditions
FHSA (First Home Savings Account) · federal	Contribute up to $8,000 a year and $40,000 lifetime. Contributions are tax-deductible, like an RRSP, and the withdrawal to buy is tax-free and never repaid. Unused room carries forward (up to $8,000), so up to $16,000 in one year.	18 or older, Canadian resident, not having lived in a home you owned in the current year or the previous 4 years. The account lasts at most 15 years. Without a purchase, the balance can move to your RRSP without using contribution room.
HBP (Home Buyers' Plan) · federal	Withdraw up to $60,000 from your RRSPs tax-free ($120,000 for a couple). Can be combined with the FHSA.	Funds must have been in the RRSP for at least 90 days. Repay over a maximum of 15 years (at least 1/15 per year).
Refundable tax credit for access to homeownership · Quebec (new)	Refunds the welcome tax: 100% of the first $5,000 and 25% of the excess, up to $5,875.	First-time buyer, home under $1M bought after December 31, 2025, principal residence. Advance payment available through Revenu Québec's My Account (for 2026, before December 1, 2026).
Home purchase tax credit · Quebec	Up to $1,400 (non-refundable credit).	First-time buyer (not having lived in a home you owned during the set period). Form TP-752.HA with your return.
First-time home buyers' tax credit · federal	Up to $1,500 (non-refundable credit, line 31270).	First-time buyer, claimed on your return for the year of purchase.
First-time home buyers' GST rebate · federal	Up to $50,000: GST is eliminated on a new home up to $1M, reduced between $1M and $1.5M.	New home (bought from a builder or self-built), agreement signed on or after March 20, 2025. Form GST190 or GST191.
30-year amortization · federal	Lower monthly payments thanks to a longer repayment period.	First-time buyers with an insured mortgage (down payment under 20%).
Novoclimat and Eco Plus	Novoclimat: $4,000 for a certified new home. Eco Plus (CMHC): 25% partial refund of the insurance premium.	Novoclimat: certified home built by an accredited contractor. Eco Plus: claim within 2 years of the mortgage.
Municipal programs	Some cities offer down payment help, for example Accès Famille in Quebec City.	Vary by city: check with your municipality.

Sources: Canada Revenue Agency; Revenu Québec (home purchase credit and access to homeownership credit, 2026); Centris, "Les programmes d'accès à la propriété" (June 2026).

Ready for the next step?

Get new listings that match your criteria and find out how much you can buy, with help from the mortgage brokers I work with.

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This guide provides general information and does not replace professional advice. Program amounts (FHSA, HBP, tax credit) and mortgage rules may change: confirm them with the Canada Revenue Agency, Revenu Québec or your financial institution. Sources: see the programs section. Mohammed Hadj Doula, residential real estate broker, Vendirect inc., real estate agency.